

Yoast SEO & Readability Checks - Complete Technical Guide

WooCommerce Product Upload Page Analysis

OVERALL SCORING SYSTEM

Traffic Light Colors:

- **GREEN** = 0-4 penalty points (excellent)
- **ORANGE/AMBER** = 5-6 penalty points (needs improvement)
- **RED** = 7+ penalty points (poor)
- **GREY** = No focus keyphrase entered (analysis not started)

Penalty Point System:

- **Red bullet** = 3 penalty points
- **Orange bullet** = 2 penalty points
- **Green bullet** = 0 points

Key Fact: You can have 1 red OR 2 orange bullets and still achieve an overall green score!

SEO ANALYSIS CHECKS

1. Keyphrase in Introduction

What it checks:

- Scans the first paragraph of your text for the focus keyphrase
- All words from the keyphrase must appear in the same sentence
- Preferably in the very first sentence

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Keyphrase found in the introduction (ideally first sentence)
- **ORANGE:** Keyphrase found but not ideally placed
- **RED:** Keyphrase not found in introduction

Technical Details:

- Only checks the first paragraph (everything before the first subheading or first 150 words)

- Words can be in different order within the sentence
- Starting with function words like "the," "a," "who" before the keyphrase still gets green
- Premium version also recognizes synonyms

How to fix:

- Add your focus keyphrase to your first sentence
 - Can use an anecdote first, but follow immediately with keyphrase
 - Don't force it - maintain natural flow
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2. Keyphrase Length

What it checks:

- Counts the number of content words in your keyphrase
- Different recommendations for products vs blog posts

Scoring:

- **GREEN:**
 - Products: 4+ words recommended
 - Blog posts: 1-4 words
 - Long-tail keyphrases: up to 6-8 words acceptable
- **ORANGE:** Slightly outside recommended range
- **RED:** Too short (single words) or excessively long

Technical Details:

- Function words (the, a, in, on, etc.) may not count in some languages
 - Content words are the meaningful words (nouns, verbs, adjectives)
 - Longer keyphrases are harder to rank for but may be more specific
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3. Keyphrase Density

What it checks:

- Calculates how often your keyphrase appears throughout the text
- Checks for both under-use and over-use (keyword stuffing)

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** 0.5% to 3% density (Free version)
- **GREEN:** 0.5% to 3.5% density (Premium - with word form recognition)
- **ORANGE:** Slightly outside range (0.3-0.5% or 3-4%)
- **RED:** Below 0.3% or above 4%

Technical Details:

- Calculation: $(\text{Number of keyphrase occurrences} / \text{Total words}) \times 100$
- All content words must occur in one sentence for a match
- Multiple occurrences within one sentence count multiple times
- Order of words can vary
- Minimum 100 words required for check to activate
- Premium version recognizes word forms (train/training/trained)
- Related keyphrases have separate density checks

Example:

- 100-word text with keyphrase appearing 5 times = 5% density (TOO HIGH - RED)
- 500-word text with keyphrase appearing 3 times = 0.6% density (GOOD - GREEN)

How to fix if TOO LOW:

- Add keyphrase naturally throughout the text
- Use it in subheadings, middle paragraphs, and conclusion
- Stay on topic - if it's hard to use the keyphrase, reassess your content focus

How to fix if TOO HIGH:

- Replace some instances with synonyms
- Use pronouns (it, this, that) to refer back
- Premium: Add synonyms and related keyphrases for variation

4. Keyphrase in Meta Description

What it checks:

- Whether all words from your focus keyphrase appear in the meta description
- Checks for over-use (keyword stuffing)

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** All keyphrase words appear near each other, used 1-2 times
- **ORANGE:** Missing some words or used awkwardly
- **RED:** Keyphrase not present OR used excessively (3+ times)

Technical Details:

- All words must appear in a sentence (not scattered throughout)
- Multiple matches in one sentence count multiple times
- Premium recognizes synonyms
- Google may bold your keyphrase in search results when it matches the search query

Why it matters:

- Google highlights matching terms in search results (improves CTR)
 - May use meta description to generate search snippet
 - Indirect SEO benefit through improved click-through rates
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5. Meta Description Length

What it checks:

- Character width of your meta description (uses pixels, not just character count)
- Different devices display different lengths

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** 120-156 characters
- **ORANGE:** 100-120 or 156-170 characters
- **RED:** Under 100 or over 170 characters (Cornerstone content gets red instead of orange)

Technical Details:

- Google uses pixel width, not character count (different characters have different widths)
- Mobile displays ~120 characters max
- Desktop displays ~156 characters max
- Google may ignore your description and generate its own
- Empty meta description not always penalized (Google will create one)

Visual feedback:

- Progress bar turns orange when you start typing
 - Turns green in the optimal range
 - Turns orange again if too long
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6. Keyphrase in SEO Title

What it checks:

- Whether focus keyphrase appears in your SEO title tag (not H1 heading)
- Position of keyphrase in title

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Keyphrase at or near the beginning of title
- **ORANGE:** Keyphrase present but towards the end
- **RED:** Keyphrase not in title

Technical Details:

- SEO title is the `<title>` tag in HTML, shown in search results
- Different from H1 heading (post title) shown on the page
- Function words before keyphrase still get green ("The best coffee makers" is green for "coffee makers")
- Premium recognizes word forms and synonyms
- Very strict check since title is major ranking factor

Best practices:

- Place keyphrase at beginning when possible
 - For high-competition keywords where everyone does this, try putting 1-2 words before to stand out
 - Long keyphrases: include as much as possible early in title
 - Always maintain natural readability
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7. SEO Title Width

What it checks:

- Pixel width of SEO title (not character count)
- Whether title will be cut off in search results

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Optimal width (approximately 50-60 characters, but measured in pixels)
- **ORANGE:** Too long (will be cut off in search results)
- **RED:** Not used for product pages (no penalty for short titles)

Technical Details:

- Uses pixel width because different characters have different widths
- Google has no set character limit but ~600 pixel width max
- Title may appear differently on mobile vs desktop
- Site name and separators excluded from calculation
- Preview shows both mobile and desktop versions
- Google may rewrite your title regardless

Real-time feedback:

- Green line under title in editor
 - Turns red when too long
 - Mobile and desktop previews available
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8. Keyword in Subheadings

What it checks:

- Whether at least one H2 or H3 subheading contains words from your keyword

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** At least one subheading contains keyword or synonym (30-75% of subheadings)
- **ORANGE:** No keyword in subheadings OR too many (over 75%)
- **RED:** No subheadings at all

Technical Details:

- Only checks H2 and H3 tags (not H4, H5, H6)
- At least one content word from keyword must appear
- Premium recognizes synonyms and word forms
- Don't need keyword in every subheading (30-75% is ideal)

Why it matters:

- Subheadings help structure content for readers and Google

- Shows topic relevance throughout the content
 - Improves scannability
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9. Keyphrase in Slug (URL)

What it checks:

- Whether the keyphrase appears in the page URL

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** All or most keyphrase words in URL
- **ORANGE:** Some words missing
- **RED:** Keyphrase not in URL

Technical Details:

- Slug is the URL path after your domain (example.com/your-slug-here)
- Function words (the, a, in) automatically removed from URLs
- Hyphens replace spaces
- Best to set before publishing (changing URLs later breaks links)

Example:

- Keyphrase: "best coffee makers"
 - Good slug: /best-coffee-makers/
 - Acceptable: /coffee-makers/
 - Poor: /product-123/
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10. Keyphrase Distribution (Premium Only)

What it checks:

- How evenly keyphrase is distributed throughout the text
- Prevents bunching at beginning or end

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Keyphrase evenly distributed throughout text
- **ORANGE:** Some clustering
- **RED:** All instances bunched in one section

Technical Details:

- Divides text into sections
 - Checks if keyphrase appears in each section
 - Shows visual highlights of keyphrase locations
 - Premium feature only
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11. Previously Used Keyphrase

What it checks:

- Whether this exact keyphrase is already used on another post/page

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Keyphrase is unique to this page
- **ORANGE:** N/A
- **RED:** Keyphrase already used on another page (shows which page)

Technical Details:

- Checks your entire WordPress database
- Exact match only (minor variations allowed)
- Having same keyphrase on multiple pages causes them to compete
- Premium shows which post/page has the duplicate

Why it matters:

- Keyword cannibalization: pages compete against each other
 - Google confused about which page to rank
 - Better to use unique keyphrases or consolidate content
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12. Text Length

What it checks:

- Total word count of your content

Scoring depends on content type:

Regular Posts:

- **GREEN:** 300+ words
- **ORANGE:** 250-299 words
- **RED:** Under 250 words

Product Pages:

- **GREEN:** 200+ words
- **ORANGE:** 150-199 words
- **RED:** Under 150 words

Cornerstone Content:

- **GREEN:** 900+ words
- **ORANGE:** 600-899 words
- **RED:** Under 600 words

Taxonomy Pages:

- **GREEN:** 250+ words
- **ORANGE:** 150-249 words
- **RED:** Under 150 words

Technical Details:

- Counts all visible text content
 - Excludes code, captions, and hidden elements
 - Different thresholds for different languages
 - Minimum 100 words to trigger keyphrase density check
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13. Internal Links

What it checks:

- Whether you have at least one followed internal link

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** At least 1 internal link present
- **ORANGE:** N/A
- **RED:** No internal links OR all internal links are nofollow

Technical Details:

- Must be followed links (not nofollow)
 - Links to other pages on your own website
 - Product pages often excluded from this check (want users to stay on product page)
 - Helps with site structure and passing link equity
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14. Outbound Links

What it checks:

- Whether you link to external websites

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** At least 1 external followed link
- **ORANGE:** N/A
- **RED:** No outbound links OR all are nofollow

Technical Details:

- Product pages excluded from this check
 - Should be relevant, quality external resources
 - Shows Google you're part of the web ecosystem
 - Some SEOs debate this check's importance
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15. Image Alt Attributes

What it checks:

- Do images have alt text?
- Does at least one alt text contain the keyphrase?

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Images have alt text AND at least one contains keyphrase
- **ORANGE:** Images have alt text but no keyphrase
- **RED:** Images missing alt text

Technical Details:

- Checks all `<img>` tags in content

- Premium recognizes synonyms in alt text
- Important for accessibility
- Google reads alt text to understand images

WooCommerce Products:

- Recommended to have 4+ images
 - At least one alt text should contain keyphrase
 - Other alt texts should be descriptive but varied
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16. Link with Keyphrase

What it checks:

- Whether any link anchor text contains the keyphrase

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** At least one link has keyphrase in anchor text
- **ORANGE:** N/A
- **RED:** No links contain keyphrase

Technical Details:

- Can be internal or external link
 - Anchor text is the clickable text of the link
 - Helps associate keyphrase with linked content
 - Don't over-optimize (looks spammy)
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17. Product-Specific Checks (WooCommerce)

Product Identifiers:

- GTIN8, GTIN12/UPC, GTIN13/EAN, GTIN14, ISBN, or MPN
- Helps Google show rich snippets
- **GREEN:** At least one identifier present
- **RED:** No identifiers

SKU Check:

- **GREEN:** SKU filled in

- **RED:** SKU empty

Product Image Count:

- **GREEN:** 4+ images
 - **ORANGE:** 2-3 images
 - **RED:** 0-1 images
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READABILITY ANALYSIS CHECKS

18. Flesch Reading Ease Score

What it checks:

- Overall text difficulty using mathematical formula
- Based on sentence length and syllable count

Formula:

- $206.835 - (1.015 \times \text{ASL}) - (84.6 \times \text{ASW})$
- ASL = Average Sentence Length (words per sentence)
- ASW = Average Syllables per Word

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** 60-100 (easy to read)
- **ORANGE:** 50-59 (fairly difficult)
- **RED:** 0-49 (difficult to very difficult)

Score Interpretation:

- 90-100: Very Easy (5th grade)
- 80-89: Easy (6th grade)
- 70-79: Fairly Easy (7th grade)
- 60-69: Standard (8th-9th grade) ← **TARGET FOR WEB**
- 50-59: Fairly Difficult (10th-12th grade)
- 30-49: Difficult (College level)
- 0-29: Very Difficult (Professional/Academic)

Technical Details:

- Only works reliably in English
- Counts syllables in every word
- Penalizes multisyllabic words (even common ones like "ingredients," "interesting")
- Penalizes long sentences heavily
- **NOTE:** As of Yoast 19.3, this is shown in Insights tab but no longer affects readability score
- Replaced by Word Complexity and Sentence Length assessments

Limitations:

- Oversimplifies readability
 - Common multisyllabic words penalized unfairly
 - Doesn't account for context or industry terminology
 - Technical content may need lower scores
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19. Sentence Length

What it checks:

- Percentage of sentences longer than 20 words

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** 25% or fewer sentences exceed 20 words
- **ORANGE:** 25-30% exceed 20 words
- **RED:** More than 30% exceed 20 words

Technical Details:

- Counts words in each sentence
- 20 words is default for English (varies by language)
- Click eye icon to highlight long sentences
- Sentences of exactly 20 words are OK

Why it matters:

- Long sentences require more mental effort
- Harder to scan and understand
- Mobile users especially benefit from shorter sentences

How to fix:

- Break one long sentence into 2-3 shorter ones
- Use transition words to connect related ideas across sentences
- Remove unnecessary words
- Each sentence should express one main idea

Language-specific limits:

- English: 20 words
 - Spanish: 25 words
 - French: 20 words
 - Dutch: 20 words
 - (Varies by language)
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20. Paragraph Length

What it checks:

- Word count of each paragraph

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** All paragraphs under 150 words
- **ORANGE:** Some paragraphs 150-200 words
- **RED:** Paragraphs over 200 words

Technical Details:

- Counts words between paragraph breaks
- Click eye icon to highlight long paragraphs
- More than 200 words is "wall of text"
- Mobile users especially affected

Best practices:

- Keep paragraphs 2-5 sentences typically
- One main idea per paragraph
- Start with topic sentence
- OK to have some 1-sentence paragraphs for emphasis

- Break up with subheadings if content gets lengthy

How to fix:

- Identify separate ideas within long paragraph
 - Break where natural pauses occur
 - Add subheadings to separate sections
 - Don't just delete content - restructure it
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21. Subheading Distribution

What it checks:

- How long sections of text are between subheadings
- Whether content is broken up with H2/H3 tags

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** No section has more than 300 words without a subheading
- **ORANGE:** Some sections 300-350 words
- **RED:** Sections over 350 words without subheading

Technical Details:

- Counts words between H2 and H3 tags
- Only applies to texts over 300 words total
- Product pages: only kicks in over 300 words
- Shows as grey if no subheadings exist

Why it matters:

- Readers scan headings before reading
- Helps people find relevant sections
- Shows content structure
- Improves SEO (Google reads heading hierarchy)

Best practices:

- Use H2 for main sections
- Use H3 for subsections
- Headings should describe what follows

- Don't overdo it (not every paragraph needs a heading)
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22. Transition Words

What it checks:

- Percentage of sentences containing transition words

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** 30% or more sentences contain transition word/phrase
- **ORANGE:** 20-30% contain transition words
- **RED:** Less than 20% contain transition words

Technical Details:

- Checks against database of transition words per language
- Words like: however, therefore, for example, in addition, consequently, moreover
- Must be used correctly (not just present)
- Different lists for different languages

Categories of transition words:

- **Enumeration:** first, also, furthermore, finally
- **Causation:** because, therefore, consequently, thus
- **Comparison:** similarly, likewise, in the same way
- **Contrast:** however, but, on the other hand, nevertheless
- **Emphasis:** indeed, in fact, of course, certainly
- **Conclusion:** in conclusion, to sum up, in summary
- **Time:** meanwhile, subsequently, previously, then
- **Example:** for example, for instance, such as

Why it matters:

- Shows relationships between ideas
- Makes text flow better
- Helps readers follow your logic
- Reduces cognitive load

How to fix:

- Review each paragraph
 - Add connecting words where ideas relate
 - Don't force them - must be natural
 - Aim for 1 per paragraph or every 2 paragraphs
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23. Passive Voice

What it checks:

- Percentage of sentences written in passive voice

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** 10% or fewer sentences in passive voice
- **ORANGE:** 10-15% in passive voice
- **RED:** More than 15% in passive voice

Technical Details:

- Passive voice: subject receives action ("The ball was thrown")
- Active voice: subject performs action ("John threw the ball")
- Algorithm checks for "to be" verbs + past participles
- Click eye icon to highlight passive sentences
- Sometimes gives false positives

Structure:

- Passive: [Object] + [be verb] + [past participle] + (by [subject])
- "The product was designed (by our team)"
- Active: [Subject] + [verb] + [object]
- "Our team designed the product"

Why passive is problematic:

- More wordy
- Less engaging
- Reduces clarity
- Distances reader from action

- Requires more cognitive effort

When passive is OK:

- Actor unknown: "The monument was built in 1850"
- Actor unimportant: "Mistakes were made"
- Emphasizing recipient: "The president was elected"
- Scientific writing conventions

How to fix:

- Identify the actor (who is doing the action)
 - Move actor to beginning of sentence
 - Change verb form to active
 - Sometimes requires complete rewrite
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24. Consecutive Sentences

What it checks:

- Whether 3+ sentences in a row start with the same word

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** No instances of 3+ consecutive sentences starting same
- **ORANGE:** N/A
- **RED:** 3 or more sentences start with same word

Technical Details:

- Checks first word of each sentence
- Very strict: even articles (the, a) counted
- Click eye icon to highlight problematic sequences
- Some false positives with intentional repetition

Common culprits:

- Transition words: "And," "But," "So"
- Pronouns: "It," "This," "They," "We"
- Articles: "The"

When it's OK to ignore:

- Intentional stylistic choice
- List of parallel questions ("Do you...", "Do you...", "Do you...")
- Rhetorical effect
- Short, punchy sentences for emphasis

How to fix:

- Change word order: "First, I went" → "I went first"
 - Use synonyms: "The company" → "The organization" → "The firm"
 - Vary sentence structure
 - Combine sentences
 - Use pronouns strategically
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25. Word Complexity (Newer Check)

What it checks:

- Percentage of complex words (those not on basic vocabulary list)

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Complex words within acceptable range for audience
- **ORANGE:** Slightly too many complex words
- **RED:** Too many complex words

Technical Details:

- Replaced Flesch score in Yoast 19.3+
- Checks against database of common words
- More nuanced than just syllable count
- Language-specific word lists

Why it's better than Flesch:

- "Watermelon" is common (not complex)
- "Paradigm" is complex (even though short)
- Context-aware
- More actionable feedback

26. Text Presence

What it checks:

- Whether there is any text content at all

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Text present
- **RED:** No text content

Technical Details:

- Basic sanity check
 - Ensures content exists before running other checks
 - Minimum threshold varies by content type
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27. Single H1

What it checks:

- Whether page has exactly one H1 heading

Scoring:

- **GREEN:** Exactly one H1
- **ORANGE:** N/A
- **RED:** Zero H1s OR multiple H1s

Technical Details:

- H1 should be your page/post title
 - Only one per page (SEO best practice)
 - Helps establish page hierarchy
 - Post title usually automatically becomes H1
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PRODUCT-SPECIFIC READABILITY ADJUSTMENTS

Different Thresholds for Products:

- **Minimum text:** 200 words (vs 300 for posts)
- **Subheading distribution:** Only kicks in over 300 words

- **Sentence length:** Same 20-word limit
- **Paragraph length:** Same 150-word max

Product-Only Checks:

- **List presence:** At least one ordered/unordered list
 - **Short description:** Short description field filled with adequate length
 - **No link checks:** Internal/external links not required (keeps users on product page)
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PRACTICAL TIPS FOR GREEN SCORES

Quick Wins (Easiest to Fix):

1. Add focus keyphrase to first sentence
2. Add focus keyphrase to meta description
3. Add focus keyphrase to at least one subheading
4. Fill in product identifiers (WooCommerce)
5. Add alt text to images with keyphrase in at least one

Medium Effort:

6. Break up long sentences (over 20 words)
7. Break up long paragraphs (over 150 words)
8. Add subheadings every 300 words
9. Add transition words (aim for 30% of sentences)
10. Convert passive voice to active

More Complex:

11. Adjust keyphrase density (0.5-3%)
 12. Improve Flesch score (sentence length + word choice)
 13. Ensure keyphrase distribution throughout text
 14. Optimize SEO title width while keeping keyphrase early
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TOOLS TO HELP

1. **Hemingway Editor** - Highlights complex sentences, passive voice
2. **Grammarly** - Grammar and readability suggestions

3. **Yoast's built-in highlighter** - Click eye icon to see problem areas
 4. **Syllable counters** - For checking Flesch score components
 5. **Transition word lists** - Reference while writing
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IMPORTANT NOTES

- **Don't chase perfection:** Focus on overall green score, not every individual check
 - **Know your audience:** Technical content may need different thresholds
 - **Quality over metrics:** User experience trumps Yoast scores
 - **Context matters:** Some red bullets may be intentional style choices
 - **Premium benefits:** Word form recognition, synonyms, keyphrase distribution
 - **Language-specific:** Many checks work differently in different languages
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SCORING PRIORITY (What Matters Most)

Critical (Must be green):

1. Keyphrase in title
2. Keyphrase in introduction
3. Text length
4. Keyphrase in URL

Very Important (Should be green):

5. Keyphrase density
6. Meta description length
7. Meta description keyphrase
8. SEO title width
9. Sentence length
10. Paragraph length

Important (Nice to have green):

11. Keyphrase in subheadings
12. Images with alt text
13. Subheading distribution

14. Transition words

Less Critical (Can be orange/red):

15. Passive voice (10% is strict; 15-20% often OK)

16. Flesch score (depends on audience)

17. Consecutive sentences (sometimes stylistic)

18. Outbound links (debatable importance)

19. Link with keyphrase

Remember: Yoast is a guide, not a rulebook. Write for humans first, optimize for search engines second!